The city of Delhi, shorn of its last link to Mughal grandeur, became even more of a backwater. Within the Red Fort, many of the Mughal structures were torn down to make way for the barracks that one sees today. A few years later, a large part of the old city would be cleared to make way for the railways. Only a handful of structures remain to remind one of Shah Jehan's dream. This completes the third cycle of India's urbanization. It had begun with the sacking of Prithviraj Chauhan's Delhi and ended six and a half centuries later with the sacking of Mughal Delhi. The next cycle, however, was well under way in Calcutta, Madras and Bombay.

After the fall of Delhi, the British proceeded to systematically put down the other centres of rebellion. Tens of thousands were executed as punishment. This is not the place to analyse the many reasons for the failure of the revolt. Despite the extraordinary courage shown by individuals such as Rani Laxmibai of Jhansi, the rebellion was probably too uncoordinated to succeed. The British were able to pick off each group one by one. For all its fame, the fort at Jhansi is a modest affair. It still contains two of Rani Laxmibai's cannons, of a design that would have been considered antiquated by the mid-nineteenth century and stood no chance against modern British cannonry. Standing on the ramparts of Jhansi fort, I could still feel the spirit of the twenty-two-year-old queen—her isolation, her audacity in defying the most powerful empire of that time, and the complete hopelessness of her cause.

It may hurt our nationalist pride to admit this today but many Indians either remained indifferent or were loyal to the British. Perhaps they feared a return to the chaos of the eighteenth century. Perhaps, they simply did not think that their future lay in going back to the old feudal order. The year 1857 saw another revolution that would have a much more lasting impact. Three federal examining universities on the pattern of London University were established in the cities of Calcutta, Bombay and Madras. By the time India became independent in 1947, twenty-five such institutions would have been set up. The universities would create an educated middle class that would be at the forefront of the next round of resistance to British rule.